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27 of the Hardest Riddles Ever—Can You Solve Them?



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**BY Molly Pennington, PhD****UPDATED ON** May 07, 2025

Think you're a pro at solving hard riddles? Put yourself and others to the test, and find out. (Don't worry—answers are included!)

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Test your mind with these hard riddles

Riddles are language **brain teasers** that use lateral thinking to come to a conclusion. They run the gamut from simple and easy to solve to serious brain-busters. Think you're a riddle master? Well, we've gathered some of the trickiest **hard riddles** that will truly challenge your skills.

Below, you'll discover a **collection of riddles** that cover all sorts of topics, from colors and food to family and numbers. These hard riddles are designed to be tricky but also fun. Just imagine the satisfaction of cracking one, two or even all of them.

So read on and see if you can solve some of the hardest riddles out there. You just might surprise yourself!

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**I speak without a mouth
and hear without ears.
I have no body, but I
come alive with wind.
What am I?**



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1. I speak without a mouth and hear without ears. I have no body, but I come alive with wind. What am I?

This hard riddle relies on tricking you into thinking about ears and a mouth. You get a tiny hint about wind to encourage you to think broadly and avoid the literal.

Answer: An echo.

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**You measure my life in
hours and I serve you
by expiring. I'm quick
when I'm thin and slow
when I'm fat. The wind
is my enemy.**



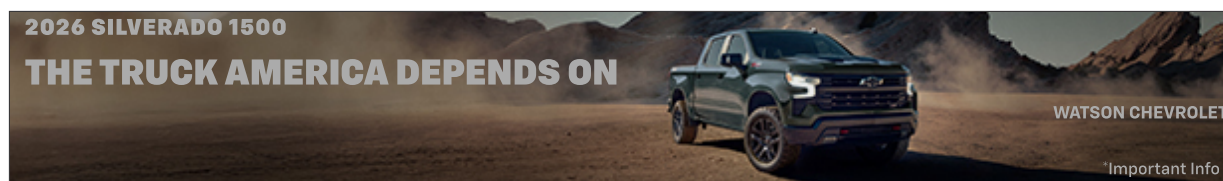
READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

2. You measure my life in hours and I serve you by expiring. I'm quick when I'm thin and slow when I'm fat. The wind is my enemy.

This riddle tries to trip you up by hitting you with details from every angle. But the big hint comes at the end with the wind. What does wind threaten most? You have to stretch your brain to come up with something tiny and unexpected.

Answer: A candle.

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**I have cities, but no houses.
I have mountains, but no trees.
I have water, but no fish.
What am I?**



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3. I have cities, but no houses. I have mountains, but no trees. I have water, but no fish. What am I?

This challenging riddle aims to confuse you and get you to focus on the things that are missing: the houses, trees and fish. You might guess you need to think about something inanimate.

Answer: A map.

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**What is seen in the
middle of March and April
that can't be seen at the
beginning or end
of either month?**



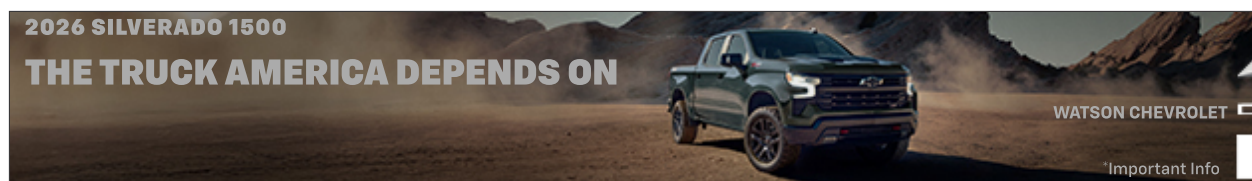
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4. What is seen in the middle of March and April that can't be seen at the beginning or end of either month?

This hard riddle works by trying to get you to think about the weather or holidays or other events linked to a calendar. To get this one right, you actually need to get super literal.

Answer: The letter *R*.

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**You see a boat filled
with people. It has not sunk,
but when you look again
you don't see a single
person on the boat.**

Why?



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5. You see a boat filled with people. It has not sunk, but when you look again you don't see a single person on the boat. Why?

Hard riddles like this can be tricky for kids because they seem to invite straightforward, logical thinking. You may come up with answers like “they all went below deck” or “they jumped overboard.” But you need to focus on the word *single* and think about its other meanings.

Answer: All the people were married.

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What word in the English language does the following: the first two letters signify a male, the first three letters signify a female, the first four letters signify a great, while the entire word signifies a great woman. What is the word?



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6. What word in the English language does the following:

The first two letters signify a male, the first three letters signify a female, the first four letters signify a great, while the entire word signifies a great woman. What is the word?

This **long riddle** is hard because it gets you thinking about genders and the ways they're different. You have to think of one word that holds the others. It's easy when you think about it!

Answer: Heroine.

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**What English
word has three
consecutive
double letters?**



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7. What English word has three consecutive double letters?

This one seems pretty impossible, but use the facts you know about English to get on track. First, think of words with double vowels. And you must know this is probably

going to be a compound word. The first and last letters of those combined words will form one set of double letters. Now, just rack your brain!

Answer: Bookkeeper.

**A woman shoots
her husband, then
holds him underwater
for five minutes.
Next, she hangs him.
Right after, they enjoy
a lovely dinner.
Explain.**



READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

8. A woman shoots her husband, then holds him underwater for five minutes. Next, she

hangs him. Right after, they enjoy a lovely dinner. Explain.

This **puzzle** aims to throw you off balance with shock. But pay attention to the first verb, “shoots.” What else can you shoot with besides a gun? There lies the key to the whole thing.

Answer: She took a picture of him and developed it in her darkroom.

**I come from a mine
and get surrounded
by wood always.
Everyone uses me.
What am I?**



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9. I come from a mine and get surrounded by wood always. Everyone uses me. What am I?

The idea of a mine might lead you to coal or a diamond. The wood detail is your best hint. This short riddle truly is a toughie, but the wood part might lead you to figure it out.

Answer: Pencil lead.

A girl has as many brothers as sisters, but each brother has only half as many brothers as sisters. How many brothers and sisters are there in the family?



10. A girl has as many brothers as sisters, but each brother has only half as many brothers as sisters. How many brothers and sisters are there in the family?

This hard riddle sounds like a tongue twister and gives you a bunch of ways to get totally confused when you try to figure out the answer. The key is to keep it simple. Be sure to count the sisters and brothers in total and in terms of their own number of siblings. Then the answer gets a little easier.

Answer: Four sisters and three brothers.

**What disappears
as soon as you say
its name?**



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11. What disappears as soon as you say its name?

Hard riddles like this one require you to think logically or in a straightforward way. At the same time, it employs a conceptual metaphor with the notion of something disappearing. The answer seems so simple—but not until you've figured it out! Before that moment, it's got your brain in a twist.

Answer: Silence.

How can the
number four be
half of five?



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12. How can the number four be half of five?

You might start doing some elaborate fractions, but hard riddles like this are sometimes much more about wordplay than crunching the numbers. It's a great riddle for teens, but have them think literally and the answer may appear right before their eyes.

Answer: IV, the Roman numeral for four, which is "half" (two letters) of the word *five*.

**I have keys,
but no locks and space,
and no rooms. You can
enter, but you can't
go outside.
What am I?**



READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

13. I have keys, but no locks and space, and no rooms. You can enter, but you can't go outside. What am I?

This hard riddle tricks you by having you think about space that can be entered. Then it gets you to merge that with a space without rooms where you can't leave. You might even be hung up on those keys. That's where you should linger. Think about that word. What are some other meanings of keys—especially those that don't require locks?

Answer: A keyboard.

**What gets wet
while drying?**



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14. What gets wet while drying?

Wet and dry seem like they always have to be opposite, so it's easy to miss the simple answer here. Think of an object that can (hint!) absorb or be both.

Answer: A towel.

How many letters
are in the alphabet?



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15. How many letters are in the alphabet?

Some hard riddles are confusing because they send you to the easiest answer first. You got this one easily, right? Twenty-six—if you're talking about the English alphabet. Not so fast. Take another look from a different perspective.

Answer: There are 11 letters in “the alphabet.”

**A is the brother of B.
B is the brother of C.
C is the father of D.
So how is D related to A?**



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**16. A is the brother of B. B is the brother of C.
C is the father of D. So how is D related to A?**

Hard riddles try to derail your train of thought, sending it into multiple directions. For this one, the key is to follow the logic. Using letters as placeholders for names like “Uncle Bob” or “Aunt Linda” makes straightforward relationships seem a lot more difficult.

Answer: A is D’s uncle.

What are the next
three letters in this
combination?
OTTFSS



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17. What are the next three letters in this combination? OTTFSS

This trick question asks you to determine the relationship between the letters. They seem random: a vowel, two consonants from the tail of the alphabet, two from the front, then two more. What could they mean? What's the pattern? In this case, think of common strings of words to get you closer.

Answer: E N T. (Each letter represents the first letter in the written numbers: One, Two, Three, Four, Five, etc.)

**This belongs to
you, but everyone
else uses it.**



READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

18. This belongs to you, but everyone else uses it.

The key to this hard riddle is to think of anything else but an actual object. Use your critical-thinking skills to get conceptual on this one.

Answer: Your name.

**First, think of the
color of the clouds. Next,
think of the color of snow.
Now, think of the color
of a bright full moon.
Now answer quickly:
What do cows drink?**



READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

19. First, think of the color of the clouds. Next, think of the color of snow. Now, think of the color of a bright full moon. Now answer quickly: What do cows drink?

This challenging riddle works by getting your brain to go through a series of associations so you get locked in and can't think of alternatives. Be careful! Is the question really connected to that color you were asked to think about? Most folks say that cows drink milk because they're fixated on the color white.

Answer: Water.

**How is seven different
from the rest of the
numbers between
one and ten?**



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20. How is seven different from the rest of the numbers between one and ten?

When trying to solve this math riddle, you may start thinking about prime numbers or which numbers are divisible by seven or if it can be cubed. Avoid thinking about math altogether, and instead think about the literal quality of the words that signify the numbers. Remember that hard riddles play with the differences between the literal and the conceptual, or the straightforward and the complex. For this riddle, think simple, but pivot to a paradigm separate from numbers.

Answer: Seven has two syllables, and the other numbers have only one syllable.

**First you eat me,
then you get eaten.
What am I?**



READER'S DIGEST, GETTY IMAGES

21. First you eat me, then you get eaten. What am I?

Hard riddles often get you used to thinking about metaphors and concepts—but not this one! Keep it simple and literal to get to the solution. But ask yourself who or what the “you” is.

Answer: A fishhook.

**What comes once
in a minute, twice in
a moment, but never
in a thousand years?**



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22. What comes once in a minute, twice in a moment, but never in a thousand years?

Again, riddles like this often have you crunching the numbers and stretching your brain cells thinking about time and the way it works. By now, you might have figured out that number riddles rarely involve math.

Answer: The letter *M*.

**Which word in
the dictionary
is always spelled
incorrectly?**



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23. Which word in the dictionary is always spelled incorrectly?

Hard riddles obsess over wordplay and word games. But this one isn't an **Einstein riddle**. In fact, it has such an easy answer that it messes with your head by getting you to think in a complex way—even though the situation doesn't call for that.

Answer: *Incorrectly.*

**What can you hold
in your right hand,
but never in your
left hand?**



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24. What can you hold in your right hand, but never in your left hand?

Take it slow and easy with this hard riddle. Perhaps if take a look at your own hands, that might give you a clue based on logic.

Answer: Your left hand.

**How can you
physically stand
behind your father
while he is standing
behind you?**



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25. How can you physically stand behind your father while he is standing behind you?

For this kind of super tricky riddle, try mapping out the physical relationship in your head. This riddle works by tricking you into thinking about impossibilities.

Answer: You are standing back-to-back with your father.

**What is able to go up
a chimney when down
but unable to go down
a chimney when up?**



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26. What is able to go up a chimney when down but unable to go down a chimney when up?

Try to think out of the box for this one. It may not be something you would normally find in your chimney.

Answer: An umbrella.

**Three different doctors
said that Paul is their
brother yet Paul claims
he has no brothers.
Who is lying?**



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27. Three different doctors said that Paul is their brother, yet Paul claims he has no brothers. Who is lying?

Visualize your family tree. That may help with this one.

Answer: No one is lying because the three doctors are Paul's sisters.

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